

Commission's OMISSIONS

Internal bickerings don't inspire confidence in the poll panel as the country gears up for elections that are expected to be agonisingly close



CEC GOPALASWAMI FLANKED
BY ELECTION COMMISSIONERS
S.Y. QURAISHI (LEFT) AND CHAWLA

| By Shafi Rahman |

Over the years, the Election Commission (EC) has been a firm, if faceless, facilitator for holding elections in the world's largest democracy. It was even fashionable to say that democracy in India owed its success in some measure to the quality and the independence of the poll regulator, the EC.

Not any more. Last week, the multi-member commission's much-vaunted impartiality stood exposed after Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) N. Gopalaswami recommended to President Pratibha Patil that Election Commissioner Navin Chawla be removed on the grounds of bias. The leak-athons that followed came from all parties involved and

with politicians taking sides, a huge question mark now hangs over the commission as it once again prepares to hold the largest electoral exercise in the world in a few months' time.

The charges and retribution have bordered on the nasty. Gopalaswami believes Chawla's frequent visits to the washroom during EC meetings had more to do with leaking the commission's proceedings to Congress leaders. Though accused of toeing the Congress's line, Chawla was said to have been in favour of issuing a notice to Sonia Gandhi for her infamous "*maut ke saudagar*" (merchants of death) speech during the last Gujarat Assembly election but did not want it to be known that

he had backed the move. A mysterious "outsider" is said to have called the CEC and asked him about the reported differences of opinion within the commission. When the CEC denied it, the caller quoted Chawla as having told a senior media personality about the differences within the commission. Gopalaswami later accused Chawla of leaking the news. To that, Chawla's retorted: "Who is your source?" The CEC shot back saying he would divulge it on April 20, the day he retires. Gopalaswami quotes other incidents to buttress his point that Chawla was a mole (*see box*).

The significance of the unexpected turn of events lay not in Gopalaswami's allegations but its timing. The CEC will